

CHAPTER 2 — The Girl at Arrivals

The city thinned as Elias approached the airport.

Terraced streets gave way to warehouses, chain-link fencing and long stretches of road built for vehicles larger than his hatchback. Aircraft moved above the roofs in slow, impossible-looking descents, their shadows passing over storage yards and hotel signs before the sound reached the ground.

The navigation app directed him towards Short Stay.

Elias followed the signs and immediately regretted it.

The price board at the entrance listed charges in increments normally associated with ransom demands.

“Twenty minutes costs what?”

The barrier lifted before he could reconsider.

He drove upwards through the multi-storey, each level smelling of warm concrete, fuel and damp air dragged in from the runways. On the top floor he found a space near the pedestrian bridge, reversed into it and switched off the engine.

The car continued ticking after him.

Metal cooling.

Fan settling.

One loose section of the dashboard vibrating because the engine had stopped but had not informed every component.

Elias checked the time.

Early.

That felt unnatural enough to be suspicious.

The envelope containing his resignation letter remained inside his jacket. Its upper edge had softened where it pressed against his ribs. He could

still turn around after the collection. Deliver the girl, return to Mac's office and leave the letter on the desk.

Friday, the letter said.

No more assignments after Friday.

A sensible plan created before Mac placed a thirteen-year-old inside it.

His phone showed the flight as landed.

No photograph.

Elias opened Mac's messages.

ZOE HARPER. THIRTEEN. FAMILY COLLECTION.

Then the destination address.

Then:

She may be difficult. Do not take it personally.

No contact number for her.

No number for the grandmother.

No passenger reference, escort details or name of the adult who had placed her on the flight.

Elias called Mac.

The call rang twice and diverted to voicemail.

"Of course."

He ended it without leaving a message.

The old pressure beneath his ribs had sharpened during the drive. He reached towards the glove compartment, stopped before opening it and instead removed the parking ticket from the dashboard.

One problem at a time.

He stepped from the car.

Wind crossed the open level hard enough to pull at his jacket. A plane rose beyond the far wall, wheels folding beneath it as it climbed through a washed-out sky.

Elias locked the hatchback and walked towards the terminal.

Behind him, the undelivered resignation letter remained against his chest.

* * *

Zoe had been awake for most of the flight.

Every time she began to sleep, movement in the aisle brought her back.

A trolley wheel striking a seat.

A child crying three rows behind.

A man opening the overhead locker and allowing his coat sleeve to brush her shoulder.

None of it was dangerous.

Her body had stopped accepting that as evidence.

She sat with the backpack between her feet and one strap wrapped around her wrist. At the departure airport, the woman escorting her had tried once to take it from her at security. Zoe had taken it back the moment it cleared the scanner.

Since boarding, she had kept it within reach.

At the arrival terminal, another uniformed employee checked Zoe's passport beneath white lights.

"Purpose of visit?"

The documents already contained the answer.

"Family visit."

"How long are you staying?"

Zoe looked towards the woman beside her.

The woman wore a plain navy coat and a plastic lanyard with no organisation printed on it. She had collected Zoe at the aircraft door, walked her through corridors and spoken to every employee before they could ask Zoe anything useful.

"Two weeks," the woman said.

The employee looked at Zoe.

"Two weeks," Zoe repeated.

A stamp descended.

The passport returned.

That was all.

No one asked why she travelled without luggage.

No one asked why the woman with her did not know the name of Zoe's grandmother without checking the paperwork.

No one asked whether Zoe wanted to continue.

The system had questions.

The folder had answers.

That appeared to be enough.

They walked through a corridor lined with advertisements for holidays, watches and private banking. Zoe understood the words but not the optimism. Everyone in the photographs looked as though doors opened because they approached them.

The woman's shoes clicked steadily beside her.

"Your uncle's driver will be waiting beyond the barrier," she said.

"He isn't my uncle's driver."

The woman continued walking.

"You were shown the photograph."

"That doesn't make him anything."

"He has been instructed."

"So were you."

The woman glanced down.

For the first time since the aircraft, her expression changed.

Not anger.

Concern that Zoe had noticed the arrangement rather than simply participating in it.

"Do exactly what he says," she replied. "He is harmless."

The sentence was too prepared.

Zoe tightened her grip on the backpack.

"Why did Mac choose someone harmless?"

The woman looked ahead again.

"You ask too many questions."

"So does everyone who wants to know where they're going."

The woman did not answer.

At the final doors she stopped beside a pillar rather than crossing into the public arrivals hall.

"Go through."

"You're not coming?"

"My responsibility ends here."

Zoe looked at the families waiting beyond the glass.

Men holding signs.

Children pressed against barriers.

Taxi drivers watching every face for payment.

Somewhere among them was Elias.

Somewhere else might be the people who had allowed her to board.

The woman touched Zoe lightly between the shoulder blades.

Zoe moved away before the pressure could become a push.

“Don’t touch me.”

Several people looked over.

The woman lowered her hand.

For one second, Zoe thought the attention might force somebody to ask the correct question.

Nobody did.

A security officer glanced towards them, saw a child, an adult and valid-looking travel papers, then returned his attention to a man arguing about a trolley.

The woman nodded towards the doors.

“Go.”

Zoe went.

* * *

Inside the terminal, artificial light flattened everything.

Coffee, disinfectant and overheated bodies mixed in the air. Families crowded the railings. A little boy ran towards an older woman and nearly knocked her over. Two taxi drivers argued quietly about whose sign had been moved. An announcement asked a passenger to return to security, then repeated the name with greater disappointment.

Elias stood near the back of the waiting crowd.

He had chosen a position with a view of both arrival doors and the corridor leading towards the exits.

Habit.

Not necessity.

He checked his phone again.

Still no photograph.

Passengers emerged in groups.

Business travellers first, walking quickly as though speed might undo the flight.

Families with trolleys.

A sports team in matching jackets.

A woman carrying flowers upside down.

Elias watched each face, estimating ages and eliminating anyone accompanied by an adult who appeared pleased to see them.

His phone buzzed.

A photograph opened without accompanying text.

Dark hair.

Pale face.

No smile.

The image had been taken indoors against a plain wall. Recent enough to be useful. Badly lit enough to conceal whether the shadows beneath her eyes belonged to the room or to her.

Thirteen, Mac had said.

The photograph looked younger around the mouth and older everywhere else.

She looks like she's had a long year, not a long flight.

A second message arrived.

SHE HAS YOUR PHOTO.

Then:

THIS MAN LOOKS HARMLESS. THAT IS WHY I CHOSE HIM.

Elias read the line twice.

Mac had apparently sent Zoe the same explanation.

Harmless.

Not reliable.

Not safe.

Not trustworthy.

Harmless.

A word selected to make a stranger easier to enter a vehicle with.

Elias put the phone away.

When he looked up, Zoe had already entered the hall.

He found her immediately.

Not because of the photograph.

Because she was the only child in Arrivals standing perfectly still while everyone around her moved.

A small backpack was held against her chest with both arms. No suitcase. No coat tied around her waist. No shopping bag from the departure lounge. Nothing she could not run with.

Her clothes were clean but wrong in small ways. The sleeves of the grey sweatshirt covered the heels of her hands. The dark trousers had been rolled once above her trainers. Chosen for size, not preference.

She looked thinner than the photograph.

Tired enough that her face had lost colour.

Her eyes moved across the hall in a deliberate order.

Exits.

Cameras.

Uniforms.

Hands.

Then faces.

She looked at Elias once.

Away.

Back again.

Confirmation rather than recognition.

A woman in a navy coat stood just inside the final doors behind her. Plain lanyard. Closed folder. No luggage.

The woman checked Elias, checked Zoe and walked towards a side corridor without approaching either of them.

No introduction.

No handover.

No request for identification.

Elias watched her leave.

That was wrong.

He looked back at Zoe.

She had seen him notice.

Her grip on the backpack tightened.

Elias stepped away from the crowd so she would not have to approach

through it.

"Zoe?"

She did not answer.

She looked him over from shoes to face.

His scuffed boots.

The old jacket.

The travel mug stain on one trouser leg.

The stiffness in his left side when he stopped moving.

Whatever the photograph had promised, the real man required a separate decision.

"Hi," Elias said. "I'm Elias. Your uncle sent me."

The word produced no visible reaction.

That was a reaction.

"Show me the message."

Her voice was quiet and slightly rough, as though she had not spoken during the flight.

Elias took out his phone.

He did not step closer.

He turned the screen towards her and held it at chest height.

Zoe stayed beyond arm's reach.

Her eyes moved over Mac's name, the photograph and the destination address. Then she compared the image Mac had sent her with the man holding the phone.

"Scroll up."

Elias did.

“More.”

He showed her the message assigning the collection.

She read everything from a distance.

“Is that enough?”

“No.”

“What else?”

“Show me the photograph he sent you.”

Elias opened it.

Zoe examined her own face on the screen without expression.

Then she nodded once.

Not agreement.

Completion of a check.

“Don’t talk to me unless I talk first,” she said. “Don’t ask questions. Don’t tell Mac anything I say. Don’t touch me. Don’t walk behind me.”

A woman waiting nearby looked towards them.

Elias kept his voice level.

“Anything else?”

“Walk in front so I can see you. Keep your hands where I can see them.”

That is not attitude.

That is procedure.

Elias lowered the phone.

“I won’t touch you.”

Zoe watched him.

“I won’t walk behind you. I won’t ask about your journey in the middle of

an airport. And I don't report conversations to Mac as a hobby."

Her eyes narrowed slightly.

"But?"

"If something becomes a safety problem, it becomes mine."

"I didn't agree to that."

"You don't have to."

"That doesn't make sense."

"It will if there's a problem."

For a moment, they stood inside the flow of passengers, neither willing to pretend the terms had been settled.

Zoe adjusted the backpack higher against her chest.

"Walk."

Elias turned towards the exit.

She followed several paces behind.

* * *

He did not look back directly.

The glass front of a closed currency exchange showed enough.

Zoe watched reflections rather than displays.

When a man towing two suitcases crossed behind her, she moved before the wheels reached her path. When a family stopped unexpectedly beside the café, she used the gap between them and a pillar rather than allowing herself to be boxed against the wall.

She was exhausted.

That made the precision worse.

People acquired habits like that through repetition.

Elias slowed near the pedestrian bridge.

Zoe slowed too, maintaining the same distance.

The resignation envelope shifted inside his jacket.

He had accepted the collection because a child might be stranded.

The child behind him did not behave like someone stranded.

She behaved like someone transferred.

At the bridge entrance, an airport employee in a bright vest stepped into their path.

"Top-floor car park is lift access only at the moment," he said.

"Escalator's being serviced."

Elias nodded.

Zoe stopped far enough back that the employee looked between them.

"Together?" he asked.

Elias looked towards Zoe rather than answering for her.

The employee waited.

Zoe said, "Yes."

The word sounded reluctant.

Elias turned back.

"Lift's this way."

He did not add anything.

The employee moved aside.

Zoe followed.

The pedestrian bridge crossed above lanes of taxis and buses. Through the glass, aircraft tails stood beyond the terminal roofs in different colours, each advertising somewhere else.

Zoe kept away from the windows.

Elias noticed she favoured open space where no one could approach from either side without being seen.

At the lift, six people waited.

A couple with matching suitcases.

A man carrying a boxed television.

A mother with a young girl who held a stuffed rabbit by one ear.

The doors opened.

Everyone entered at once.

Zoe did not.

She waited outside until Elias stepped in and moved to the far side. Then she entered last and took the rear corner beside the control panel, where she could see both doors and every reflection in the metal walls.

The mother pressed Level Two.

Elias pressed Five.

The young girl stared at Zoe's backpack.

"Are you going on holiday?"

Her mother touched her shoulder.

"Don't bother people."

Zoe looked at the rabbit.

"I just came back."

"Where from?"

The mother apologised before Zoe had to answer.

"She asks everyone questions."

Zoe said nothing.

The little girl lifted the rabbit.

“He went on the plane too.”

Zoe looked at the worn toy.

One ear had been repaired with blue thread.

“Did he like it?”

“No. He was scared.”

The child lowered her voice.

“But I held him.”

The lift stopped at Level Two.

The mother smiled apologetically as they left.

Zoe watched the rabbit disappear through the doors.

For the first time since Arrivals, her attention remained on something that was not an exit.

The doors closed.

Elias looked forward.

He allowed the moment to belong to her without examining it.

The man with the television left on Level Four.

At Level Five, Elias stepped out first.

Zoe waited until the doors began to close, then followed.

* * *

The top floor had emptied during the flight’s arrival rush.

Wind pushed litter across the concrete. A trolley rolled slowly against a kerb and stopped. The low wall around the car park revealed sections of

runway between terminal buildings.

Elias walked towards the hatchback.

Zoe stayed behind and to his right, positioned so his body did not block her view of the wider level.

He unlocked the car from several metres away.

The lights flashed.

Her eyes moved to the number plate.

Then to the exits.

Then beneath the neighbouring vehicles.

Elias opened the rear passenger door.

The car's interior looked worse beneath the car-park lighting.

Grey fabric faded almost white at the edges.

A split in the dashboard near the steering column.

Old receipts in the door pocket.

A pine-shaped air freshener that had not produced a smell in years.

The battery grinder case remained beneath the folded blanket in the boot.

Zoe stopped beside the open door.

"Get in," Elias said.

She did not.

She looked inside from above.

Rear seat.

Footwell.

Space beneath the driver's seat.

Door handle.

Lock.

Then she crouched and checked beneath the car itself.

Elias waited.

A man pushing a suitcase passed behind them and looked over.

Elias did not tell Zoe to hurry merely to make the scene appear normal.

She stood again.

"The boot."

"What about it?"

"Open it."

He pressed the release.

The boot lifted.

Zoe remained at the side of the vehicle where she could see both Elias and the open compartment.

Blanket.

Oil.

Tool case.

Emergency water.

A high-visibility jacket.

No person.

No second bag.

Elias closed it.

"You satisfied?"

"No."

“Useful answer.”

She looked at the rear door again.

“Child lock.”

“Off.”

“How do I know?”

“Test it.”

Zoe climbed onto the rear seat without placing the backpack down. She pulled the door closed, then immediately opened it from inside.

The latch released.

She closed it again.

Elias stepped back before leaning towards the opening.

“The front locks control all four doors. The rear handle still works unless I activate the child lock manually. I haven’t.”

“You could.”

“Yes.”

“Will you?”

“No.”

“Why?”

“Because I don’t need to imprison passengers to complete a journey.”

The sentence produced the smallest pause.

Zoe looked at him through the open door.

He did not know what it had touched.

She moved diagonally behind the driver’s seat and placed the backpack on her lap.

Elias closed the door gently.

He checked the parking ticket.

The payment machine stood opposite the lift, less than forty metres away.

"Two minutes," he said.

Zoe looked towards the machine, then towards the ramp.

"Leave the keys."

"No."

"You said you weren't imprisoning me."

"I'm not leaving a thirteen-year-old alone with my car keys."

"You don't trust me."

"I met you seven minutes ago."

"That's sensible."

"I thought so."

He locked the car.

The central locks dropped with a heavy mechanical clunk.

Zoe's face changed.

Only for a fraction of a second.

Elias saw it through the glass.

He unlocked the car again.

The locks rose.

Zoe looked at him.

"I need to pay," he said. "The doors stay unlocked. Do not move seats. Do not touch the handbrake. Do not start the car."

"You're leaving it unlocked?"

"You objected to being locked in."

"You could take me with you."

"I could."

"Why aren't you?"

"Because you checked the exits, the child lock and the boot. You can sit in an unlocked car for two minutes without me standing over you."

Zoe stared at him as though trying to identify the trick.

Elias held up the parking ticket.

"Two minutes."

He walked towards the machine.

* * *

Zoe watched him cross the concrete.

He did not look back immediately.

Most adults did.

They issued trust as a performance, then turned around to verify that it had been obeyed.

Elias reached the machine before glancing at the car's reflection in the lift doors.

Not at her directly.

At the entire level.

Zoe looked towards the ramp.

Down five floors.

Barrier at the bottom.

Traffic beyond.

The destination address remained on Elias's phone.

He believed he was taking her to a grandmother.

Mac had told him enough to make him move and not enough to make him choose.

Harmless.

The word returned.

Harmless men still delivered people.

Harmless men still followed instructions.

Sometimes harmless only meant they expected somebody else to perform the violence.

Zoe examined the front seats.

The driver's door was unlocked.

The keys were not inside.

The steering-column housing had split along one edge. Two screws were missing. An older repair had left a section loose enough to pull down by hand.

She had seen a driver do it once.

Not to steal a car.

To start a van after the ignition barrel failed.

Jackie had laughed because the man swore at every wire as though it had betrayed him personally.

Zoe looked back at Elias.

The payment machine rejected his ticket. He flattened it against the metal and tried again. The barrier ramp remained clear. No one stood near the car. She moved. The backpack stayed on her shoulders. Rear

seat to front. Knees against the steering column. Her feet barely reached the pedals. That did not matter yet. She pulled at the damaged plastic. It resisted. She pulled harder. One side dropped towards her legs. Wires. Old tape. A connector that had been opened before. Zoe's hands shook. She pressed them against her knees until the movement reduced. At the payment machine, Elias inserted the ticket again. The screen displayed an error. Good. Zoe separated the taped section carefully. The first two wires did nothing. The third made the dashboard lights appear. Her breath caught. She looked towards Elias. He was speaking to an attendant through the help button.

Zoe twisted the next connection. The starter clicked. Once. Not enough. She released it before the sound carried too far. Think. Ignition live. Starter separate. Clutch. Her left foot found the pedal at full extension. She pressed. The backpack shifted forward against the steering wheel. Zoe pushed it aside, tried the wires again and heard the engine cough.

Once. Across the concrete, Elias stopped speaking. The engine coughed a second time. Then it came alive.